

The Minister's Black Veil

Nathaniel Hawthorne · 1836

First published: The Token, 1836

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

AP edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

Cover: Claude Monet, Springtime (1872). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).

Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Whole-book test and answer key
6. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Twice-Told_Tales_(1837)/The_Minister's_Black_Veil (revision 9901756), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 10–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Minister's Black Veil suggest about secret sin?
- What does The Minister's Black Veil suggest about isolation?
- What does The Minister's Black Veil suggest about symbol and meaning?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: AP

AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN

AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the

app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Minister's Black Veil	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*secret sin* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Minister's Black Veil

Author biography

Nathaniel Hawthorne was born in Salem, Massachusetts, on 4 July 1804; his ancestor John Hathorne was a judge in the Salem witch trials of 1692, a family history Hawthorne felt as a burden (he added the "w" to his name). After graduating from Bowdoin College in 1825 he spent years writing in near-seclusion in Salem, publishing Twice-Told Tales in 1837. He lived briefly at the utopian Brook Farm community, worked at the Salem Custom House, and achieved fame with The Scarlet Letter (1850) and The House of the Seven Gables (1851). He served as U.S. consul in Liverpool and died on 19 May 1864 in Plymouth, New Hampshire.

Historical and cultural context

Set in a Puritan New England village, the story reflects the Calvinist belief that every person hides secret sin. Hawthorne's footnote mentions a real clergyman, Joseph Moody of York, Maine, who wore a handkerchief over his face after accidentally killing a friend.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in The Token, a gift annual, for 1836 (issued in late 1835); collected in Twice-Told Tales (1837).

Then: Edgar Allan Poe reviewed Twice-Told Tales in 1842 and praised Hawthorne, though he guessed that the veil hid a specific crime.

Now: Widely taught as a parable of secret sin and as an example of how a symbol can carry many meanings.

Overview (spoiler-free)

The Reverend Mr. Hooper appears one Sunday wearing a black veil over his face. He never explains it, and the village's reaction changes his life.

Main themes

- secret sin: everyone hides something.
- isolation: the veil cuts him off from love.
- symbolism and interpretation: the town's reactions reveal the town.

Why it matters

The story asks why we fear what we don't understand, and what we hide from others.

Spoilers · teacher only

He refuses to remove it even for his fiancée Elizabeth, who leaves him. He becomes an effective but lonely minister, and on his deathbed declares that every face wears a black veil.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open The Minister's Black Veil: Why do people react strongly to something a person wears or hides?
Prompt: Before we open The Minister's Black Veil: Why do people react strongly to something a person wears or hides?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

parable; symbol; Puritanism; ambiguity; isolation.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. Nathaniel Hawthorne was born in Salem, Massachusetts, on 4 July 1804; his ancestor John Hathorne was a judge in the Salem witch trials of 1692, a family history Hawthorne felt as a burden (he added the "w" to his name). After graduating from Bowdoin College in 1825 he spent years writing in near-seclusion in Salem, publishing Twice-Told Tales in 1837. He lived briefly at the utopian Brook Farm community, worked at the Salem Custom House, and achieved fame with The Scarlet Letter (1850) and The House of the Seven Gables (1851). He served as U.S. consul in Liverpool and died on 19 May 1864 in Plymouth, New Hampshire. The world of the book. Set in a Puritan New England village, the story reflects the Calvinist belief that every person hides secret sin. Hawthorne's footnote mentions a real clergyman, Joseph Moody of York, Maine, who wore a handkerchief over his face after accidentally killing a friend. Publication and reception. First published in The Token, a gift annual, for 1836 (issued in late 1835); collected in Twice-Told Tales (1837). Then: Edgar Allan Poe reviewed Twice-Told Tales in 1842 and praised Hawthorne, though he guessed that the veil hid a specific crime. Now: Widely taught as a parable of secret sin and as an example of how a symbol can carry many meanings.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

"I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58). Hooper's final speech.

> *I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58)*

Think-aloud: "I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58). Hooper's final speech.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): The Reverend Mr. Hooper appears one Sunday wearing a black veil over his face. He never explains it, and the village's reaction changes his life. Themes to track: secret sin: everyone hides something. isolation: the veil cuts him off from love. symbolism and interpretation: the town's reactions reveal the town.

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Minister's Black Veil: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does The Minister's Black Veil still matter? The story asks why we fear what we don't understand, and what we hide from others.
Anchor question: Why might The Minister's Black Veil still be taught today?
Facilitation: The story asks why we fear what we don't understand, and what we hide from others.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Why won't Hooper remove the veil? Answer: He wants it to stand as a symbol of the secret sin everyone hides; removing it would undo the lesson. Some readers see his own sin or pride.
Exit ticket: Why won't Hooper remove the veil?
Answer: He wants it to stand as a symbol of the secret sin everyone hides; removing it would undo the lesson. Some readers see his own sin or pride.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: The Minister's Black Veil.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "Nathaniel Hawthorne" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Nathaniel-Hawthorne); The House of the Seven Gables, "Nathaniel Hawthorne" (https://7gables.org/nathaniel-hawthorne/); Hawthorne, "The Minister's Black Veil," Twice-Told Tales (1837) (https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/508)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Hooper's motive is deliberately never explained; do not present a single reading as fact.

Lesson 2: The Minister's Black Veil

Focus: a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer

Content note (): No significant sensitive content flagged; preview as usual.
Student preview: Nothing in this story needs a special warning.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Reverend Hooper of Milford appears one Sunday wearing a black veil over his face and never removes it. The congregation is frightened; his fiancée Elizabeth begs him to lift it and leaves him when he refuses. His preaching gains power over sinners, but he lives isolated. On his deathbed he refuses to unveil, declaring that every face around him wears a black veil.

Background: Published in 1836 in The Token. Hawthorne subtitled it 'A Parable' and noted a real minister who wore a veil after an accidental killing.

Significance: A key text for teaching symbolism and ambiguity.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What things do people hide from others? Why? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to isolation because.... Content note before we start: Nothing in this story needs a special warning.
Prompt: What things do people hide from others? Why?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to isolation because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors).

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: scrupled — hesitated because of a moral doubt; neatness — tidiness and order; mildness — gentleness; pronouncing — speak, pronounce, or utter in a certain way; symptom — a sign; an indication. "scrupled": From Latin scrupulus "small sharp stone; uneasiness," the image of a pebble in one's shoe; the verb means "to hesitate on grounds of conscience."
Words: scrupled: hesitated because of a moral doubt · neatness: tidiness and order · mildness: gentleness · pronouncing: speak, pronounce, or utter in a certain way · symptom: a sign; an indication

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in 1836 in The Token. Hawthorne subtitled it 'A Parable' and noted a real minister who wore a veil after an accidental killing. A key text for teaching symbolism and ambiguity. Symbolism: The veil is never explained; it may mean sin, sorrow, the barrier between people, or the barrier between humanity and God. Characterization: Hooper is gentle but immovable; Elizabeth is the only one who speaks to him directly. Irony: The veil makes him a better preacher ("a very efficient clergyman") because sinners feel he understands them. Watch for the black veil: the hidden self.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Why do you tremble at me alone" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58). His last words begin. That is symbolism at work: The veil is never explained; it may mean sin, sorrow, the barrier between people, or the barrier between humanity and God.

> *Why do you tremble at me alone* *(The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58)*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Why do you tremble at me alone" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58). His last words begin. That is symbolism at work: The veil is never explained; it may mean sin, sorrow, the barrier between people, or the barrier between humanity and God.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: "Visage" means face; he sees every face as veiled, so the veil is a symbol of everyone's secrecy. Ask: How does this line connect to isolation? Expected: The veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). (His accusation.)

> *I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil* *(The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: "Visage" means face; he sees every face as veiled, so the veil is a symbol of everyone's secrecy.
Ask: How does this line connect to isolation?
Expected answer: The veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). (His accusation.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)

Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).

Annotate the story for symbolism, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Minister's Black Veil develops the idea of a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of symbolism and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. When the text says “I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58), it shows this directly. He asks the crowd "Why do you tremble at me alone," and says "on every visage a Black Veil," pointing out that their fear comes from their own hidden sins.

Task: Annotate the story for symbolism, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Minister's Black Veil develops the idea of a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of symbolism and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)

Exemplar: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. When the text says “I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58), it shows this directly. He asks the crowd "Why do you tremble at me alone," and says "on every visage a Black Veil," pointing out that their fear comes from their own hidden sins.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.

Anchor question: What things do people hide from others? Why? Ask: is Hooper heroic, proud, or both?

Anchor question: What things do people hide from others? Why?

Facilitation: Ask: is Hooper heroic, proud, or both?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)

Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).

Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. (“I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil”, The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer? Support it with one short quotation.

Answer: Model answer: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. (“I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil”, The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how symbolism shapes a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer. Key takeaway: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors).*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Symbolism:** The veil is never explained; it may mean sin, sorrow, the barrier between people, or the barrier between humanity and God.
- **Characterization:** Hooper is gentle but immovable; Elizabeth is the only one who speaks to him directly.
- **Irony:** The veil makes him a better preacher ("a very efficient clergyman") because sinners feel he understands them.

Themes and how they develop

- **isolation:** the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors).

Symbols and motifs

- **the black veil:** the hidden self.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Why do you tremble at me alone” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58) His last words begin.
- “I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58) His accusation.
- “a very efficient clergyman” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 45) The irony of his success.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him.
Evidence: “I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58)
Reasoning: He asks the crowd "Why do you tremble at me alone," and says "on every visage a Black Veil," pointing out that their fear comes from their own hidden sins.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
scrupled (verb)	hesitated because of a moral doubt	*A person, who watched the interview between the dead and living, scrupled not to affirm, that, at the instant*	“scrupled”: From Latin scrupulus "small sharp stone; uneasiness," the image of a pebble in one's shoe; the verb means "to

		when the clergyman's features were disclosed, the corpse had slightly shuddered, rustling the shroud and muslin cap, though the countenance retained the composure of death.	hesitate on grounds of conscience." (Online Etymology Dictionary, https://www.etymonline.com/word/scruple)
neatness (noun)	tidiness and order	*Hooper, a gentlemanly person of about thirty, though still a bachelor, was dressed with due clerical neatness, as if a careful wife had starched his band, and brushed the weekly dust from his Sunday's garb.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
mildness (noun)	gentleness	*Hooper's mildness did not forsake him.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
pronouncing (verb)	speak, pronounce, or utter in a certain way	*Finally, the deputies returned abashed to their constituents, pronouncing the matter too weighty to be handled, except by a council of the churches, if, indeed, it might not require a general synod.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
symptom (noun)	a sign; an indication	*For a few moments she appeared lost in thought, considering, probably, what new methods might be tried, to withdraw her lover from so dark a fantasy, which, if it had no other meaning, was perhaps a symptom of mental disease.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
wavering (verb)	pause or hold back in uncertainty or unwillingness	*For some time previous, his mind had been confused, wavering doubtfully between the past and the present, and hovering forward, as it were, at intervals, into the indistinctness of the world to come.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
prevailing (verb)	be larger in number, quantity, power, status or importance	*He seemed not fully to partake of the prevailing wonder, till Mr.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
exerted (verb)	put to use	*Father Hooper at, first replied merely by a feeble motion of his head; then, apprehensive, perhaps, that his meaning might be doubtful, he exerted himself to speak.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
weakened (verb)	lessen the strength of	*Hooper's eyes were so weakened by the midnight lamp, as to require a shade.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

introducing (verb)	presenting (someone) to another person	*The minister received them with friendly courtesy, but became silent, after they were seated, leaving to his visiters the whole burthen of introducing their important business.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. What things do people hide from others? Why?
2. Where does symbolism appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with secret sin?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Mr. Hooper wear? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: A black veil over his face
2. Who is Elizabeth? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: Hooper's fiancée
3. What happens at the young lady's funeral? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: Some fancy the corpse shudders as Hooper bends over it
4. What effect does the veil have on his ministry? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: He becomes powerful with sinners but feared
5. What does Hooper say on his deathbed? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.NAR] Look for: He sees a black veil on every face
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Minister's Black Veil” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: Reverend Hooper of Milford appears one Sunday wearing a black veil over his face and never removes it. The congregation is frightened; his fiancée Elizabeth begs him to lift it and leaves him when he refuses. His preaching gains power over sinners, but he lives isolated. On his deathbed he refuses to unveil, declaring that every face around him wears a black veil.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Minister's Black Veil”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Minister's Black Veil” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.SET] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “A person, who watched the interview between the dead and living, scrupled not to affirm, that, at the instant when the clergyman's features were disclosed, the corpse had slightly shuddered, rustling the

shroud and…" What does "scrupled" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: scrupled: hesitated because of a moral doubt.

10. Reread: "Hooper, a gentlemanly person of about thirty, though still a bachelor, was dressed with due clerical neatness, as if a careful wife had starched his band, and brushed the weekly dust from his Sunday's garb." What does "neatness" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: neatness: tidiness and order.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "The Minister's Black Veil" suggest about a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A key text for teaching symbolism and ambiguity.
2. Find one example of symbolism in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
3. How does the characterization in this story shape what we understand about a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: "Why do you tremble at me alone" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58): His last words begin. On characterization: Hooper is gentle but immovable; Elizabeth is the only one who speaks to him directly. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins "The color rose into her cheeks, as she intimated the nature of the rumors that were already abroad in the village.", why might Hawthorne have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in "The Minister's Black Veil", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: Reverend Hooper of Milford appears one Sunday wearing a black veil over his face and never removes it. The congregation is frightened; his fiancée Elizabeth begs him to lift it and leaves him when he refuses. His preaching gains power over sinners, but he lives isolated. On his deathbed he refuses…
6. As the opening story, what does "The Minister's Black Veil" set up that the rest of The Minister's Black Veil will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: "I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58): His accusation. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: "a very efficient clergyman" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 45): The irony of his success. On characterization: Hooper is gentle but immovable; Elizabeth is the only one who

speaks to him directly. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. The bell-ringer asked: “What things do people hide from others? Why?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does tone / mood appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with secret sin? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: Look for word choices that reveal the narrator's attitude or the scene's feeling.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: “Why do you tremble at me alone” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58): His last words begin. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in 1836 in The Token. Hawthorne subtitled it 'A Parable' and noted a real minister who wore a veil after an accidental killing. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.SET] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: “I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58): His accusation. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A key text for teaching symbolism and ambiguity.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: “a very efficient clergyman” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 45): The irony of his success. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: “Why do you tremble at me alone” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58): His last words begin. On characterization: Hooper is gentle but immovable; Elizabeth is the only one who speaks to him directly. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Minister's Black Veil” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: “I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil” (The Minister's Black

Veil, paragraph 58): His accusation. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. Write three questions of your own about "The Minister's Black Veil": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: "a very efficient clergyman" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 45): The irony of his success. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Connect this story to isolation: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Hawthorne need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: "Why do you tremble at me alone" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58): His last words begin. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Is the symbolism in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: "I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58): His accusation. On symbolism: The veil is never explained; it may mean sin, sorrow, the barrier between people, or the barrier between humanity and God. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Compare how "The Minister's Black Veil" treats a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Minister's Black Veil see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: "a very efficient clergyman" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 45): The irony of his success. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve secret sin? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: "Why do you tremble at me alone" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58): His last words begin. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: “I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58): His accusation. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. What question would you most like to ask Nathaniel Hawthorne about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: “a very efficient clergyman” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 45): The irony of his success. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Symbolism:** look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Tone / mood**: word choices that reveal the narrator's attitude or the scene's feeling

Chapter quiz

1. What does Mr. Hooper wear?
   A. A black veil over his face
   B. A hood
   C. A mask
   D. A black robe only
2. Who is Elizabeth?
   A. A widow in the congregation
   B. Hooper's fiancée
   C. The sexton's wife
   D. His sister
3. What happens at the young lady's funeral?
   A. Hooper weeps
   B. The church burns
   C. Some fancy the corpse shudders as Hooper bends over it
   D. The veil falls off
4. What effect does the veil have on his ministry?
   A. He loses his job

B. He becomes powerful with sinners but feared

C. He leaves town

D. He becomes cheerful

5. What does Hooper say on his deathbed?

A. He thanks Elizabeth

B. He asks to be unveiled

C. He confesses a crime

D. He sees a black veil on every face

6. In the line “A person, who watched the interview between the dead and living, scrupled not to affirm, that, at the instant when the clergyman's features were disclosed, the corpse had slightly shuddered, rustling the shroud and muslin cap, though the countenance retained the composure of death.”, what does “scrupled” most nearly mean?

A. tidiness and order

B. speak, pronounce, or utter in a certain way

C. gentleness

D. hesitated because of a moral doubt

7. In the line “Hooper, a gentlemanly person of about thirty, though still a bachelor, was dressed with due clerical neatness, as if a careful wife had starched his band, and brushed the weekly dust from his Sunday's garb.”, what does “neatness” most nearly mean?

A. hesitated because of a moral doubt

B. gentleness

C. tidiness and order

D. speak, pronounce, or utter in a certain way

Answer key: 1. A (A black veil over his face); 2. B (Hooper's fiancée); 3. C (Some fancy the corpse shudders as Hooper bends over it); 4. B (He becomes powerful with sinners but feared); 5. D (He sees a black veil on every face); 6. D (hesitated because of a moral doubt); 7. C (tidiness and order)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Minister's Black Veil,” how does Hawthorne show a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the symbolism you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; AP: see unit standards): In The Minister's Black Veil, how does Hawthorne develop the idea of a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the symbolism in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; AP: see unit standards): Analyze how The Minister's Black Veil develops the idea of a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of

textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of symbolism and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; AP: see unit standards): Analyze how the structure of The Minister's Black Veil (where it begins, turns and ends) and its symbolism shape the reader's understanding of a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Two readers disagree about what The Minister's Black Veil suggests about a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's symbolism and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Nathaniel Hawthorne uses symbolism in The Minister's Black Veil to complicate the reader's understanding of a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Situate The Minister's Black Veil within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; AP: see unit standards): Read The Minister's Black Veil alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer follows or bends those conventions, using the symbolism as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; AP: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Minister's Black Veil and its treatment of a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's symbolism and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; AP: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Minister's Black Veil as evidence for a larger claim about a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer in The Minister's Black Veil. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; AP: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Minister's Black Veil as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Minister's Black Veil.

SAT-style questions

1. *Hooper's mildness did not forsake him.*

As used in the text, what does the word "mildness" most nearly mean?

A. gentleness

B. put to use

C. lessen the strength of

D. presenting (someone) to another person

2. *The color rose into her cheeks, as she intimated the nature of the rumors that were already abroad in the village. But Mr. Hooper's mildness did not forsake him. He even smiled again—that same sad smile, which always appeared like a faint glimmering of light, proceeding from the obscurity beneath the veil.*

Which choice best states a central concern of "The Minister's Black Veil"?

A. Harlem as promised refuge and trap

B. A girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval

C. Friendship tested by duty

D. A symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer

SAT key: 1. A (gentleness); 2. D (A symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer)

Whole-book test

The Minister's Black Veil: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. What does Mr. Hooper wear?
   A. A black veil over his face
   B. A hood
   C. A mask
   D. A black robe only
2. Who is Elizabeth?
   A. A widow in the congregation
   B. Hooper's fiancée
   C. The sexton's wife
   D. His sister
3. What happens at the young lady's funeral?
   A. Hooper weeps
   B. The church burns
   C. Some fancy the corpse shudders as Hooper bends over it
   D. The veil falls off
4. What effect does the veil have on his ministry?
   A. He loses his job
   B. He becomes powerful with sinners but feared
   C. He leaves town
   D. He becomes cheerful
5. What does Hooper say on his deathbed?
   A. He thanks Elizabeth
   B. He asks to be unveiled
   C. He confesses a crime
   D. He sees a black veil on every face
6. In the line “A person, who watched the interview between the dead and living, scrupled not to affirm, that, at the instant when the clergyman's features were disclosed, the corpse had slightly shuddered, rustling the shroud and muslin cap, though the countenance retained the composure of death.”, what does “scrupled” most nearly mean?
   A. tidiness and order
   B. speak, pronounce, or utter in a certain way
   C. gentleness
   D. hesitated because of a moral doubt

7. In the line “Hooper, a gentlemanly person of about thirty, though still a bachelor, was dressed with due clerical neatness, as if a careful wife had starched his band, and brushed the weekly dust from his Sunday's garb.”, what does “neatness” most nearly mean?
   A. hesitated because of a moral doubt
   B. gentleness
   C. tidiness and order
   D. speak, pronounce, or utter in a certain way
8. As used in the story (“A person, who watched the interview between the dead and living, scrupled not to affirm, that, at the instant when the clergyman's features ”), what does “scrupled” mean?
   A. hesitated because of a moral doubt
   B. a sign; an indication
   C. put to use
   D. tidiness and order
9. As used in the story (“Hooper, a gentlemanly person of about thirty, though still a bachelor, was dressed with due clerical neatness, as if a careful wife had star”), what does “neatness” mean?
   A. pause or hold back in uncertainty or unwillingness
   B. tidiness and order
   C. lessen the strength of
   D. gentleness
10. As used in the story (“Hooper's mildness did not forsake him.”), what does “mildness” mean?
    A. be larger in number, quantity, power, status or importance
    B. presenting (someone) to another person
    C. gentleness
    D. speak, pronounce, or utter in a certain way
11. As used in the story (“Finally, the deputies returned abashed to their constituents, pronouncing the matter too weighty to be handled, except by a council of the c”), what does “pronouncing” mean?
    A. put to use
    B. hesitated because of a moral doubt
    C. a sign; an indication
    D. speak, pronounce, or utter in a certain way
12. As used in the story (“For a few moments she appeared lost in thought, considering, probably, what new methods might be tried, to withdraw her lover from so dark a”), what does “symptom” mean?
    A. a sign; an indication
    B. lessen the strength of
    C. tidiness and order
    D. pause or hold back in uncertainty or unwillingness

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how secret sin develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

2. Explain how isolation develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how symbol and meaning develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (secret sin, isolation, symbol and meaning) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. A (A black veil over his face); 2. B (Hooper's fiancée); 3. C (Some fancy the corpse shudders as Hooper bends over it); 4. B (He becomes powerful with sinners but feared); 5. D (He sees a black veil on every face); 6. D (hesitated because of a moral doubt); 7. C (tidiness and order); 8. A (hesitated because of a moral doubt); 9. B (tidiness and order); 10. C (gentleness); 11. D (speak, pronounce, or utter in a certain way); 12. A (a sign; an indication)

Essay assignments

Essay: Secret sin

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Minister's Black Veil teaches about secret sin. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops secret sin in The Minister's Black Veil. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops secret sin across The Minister's Black Veil. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Minister's Black Veil (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of secret sin. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of secret sin in The Minister's Black Veil. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Nathaniel Hawthorne's choices in The Minister's Black Veil (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of secret sin, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Minister's Black Veil's treatment of secret sin in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on secret sin in The Minister's Black Veil that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on secret sin in The Minister's Black Veil. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about secret sin in The Minister's Black Veil, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on secret sin in The Minister's Black Veil, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Isolation

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Minister's Black Veil teaches about isolation. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops isolation in The Minister's Black Veil. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops isolation across The Minister's Black Veil. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Minister's Black Veil (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of isolation. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of isolation in The Minister's Black Veil. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Nathaniel Hawthorne's choices in The Minister's Black Veil (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of isolation, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Minister's Black Veil's treatment of isolation in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on isolation in The Minister's Black Veil that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on isolation in The Minister's Black Veil. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about isolation in The Minister's Black Veil, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on isolation in The Minister's Black Veil, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Symbol and meaning

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Minister's Black Veil teaches about symbol and meaning. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops symbol and meaning in The Minister's Black Veil. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops symbol and meaning across The Minister's Black Veil. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Minister's Black Veil (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of symbol and meaning. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of symbol and meaning in The Minister's Black Veil. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Nathaniel Hawthorne's choices in The Minister's Black Veil (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of symbol and meaning, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Minister's Black Veil's treatment of symbol and meaning in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on symbol and meaning in The Minister's Black Veil that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on symbol and meaning in The Minister's Black Veil. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about symbol and meaning in The Minister's Black Veil, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on symbol and meaning in The Minister's Black Veil, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary, 2026-10-20); other words are student look-ups. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.